DRUGS · NASAL PREPARATIONS

Azelastine and combination sprays

Azelastine is a topical H1 antihistamine with mast-cell stabilising and anti-inflammatory effects, acting within 15 to 30 minutes. It treats allergic rhinitis alone, but its main role is in combination with fluticasone in a single spray, which works better than either drug alone for moderate to severe allergic rhinitis. It also helps some patients with non-allergic rhinitis.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The drug on one page.

1.1 Summary

AZELASTINE AND COMBINATION SPRAYS

	SUMMARY
Preparations	Azelastine 0.1% spray (137 micrograms per spray); azelastine with fluticasone propionate (137 and 50 micrograms per spray); olopatadine with mometasone is a newer combination
How it works	H1 antagonism, mast-cell stabilisation and reduced inflammatory mediator release
ENT uses	Seasonal and perennial allergic rhinitis; moderate to severe allergic rhinitis not controlled by a nasal steroid; allergic conjunctivitis (eye drops); some non-allergic rhinitis
Adult dose	Azelastine 1 spray into each nostril twice daily; combination 1 spray into each nostril twice daily
Child dose	Azelastine from 6 years (1 spray each nostril twice daily); the combination from 12 years

2 CHAPTER TWO Using it in ENT

Indications.

2.1 Place in treatment

Use a nasal steroid first for persistent or moderate to severe allergic rhinitis. When it is not enough, the steroid-antihistamine combination spray (ARIA and BSACI guidance) is the next step, before adding oral treatments. Its rapid onset helps patients who take sprays only when symptomatic.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

A **bitter taste** (the commonest complaint; tilting the head forward helps), epistaxis, headache and, uncommonly, drowsiness. The combination adds the steroid's effects.

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Where the combination spray fits in the ARIA stepwise approach.

- Speed of onset compared with nasal steroids.

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Adding an oral antihistamine before trying the combination spray in a patient on a steroid alone.

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